

Saada Amadu

Berkeley, CA • saadaamadu@gmail.com

EDUCATION

University of California, Berkeley

2024 – Present

Ph.D. in City and Regional Planning

Concentration: Food Systems and Applied Data Science

Designated Emphasis in Political Economy

Central European University, Budapest, Hungary

2017

M.S. in Environmental Sciences & Policy

Thesis: From Land Grabbing to Sustainable Land Investments: Effects of Large-Scale Land Transactions on the Environment and Rural Livelihoods in Ghana

College of Staten Island, New York, NY

2016

B.A. in International Studies

Honors Thesis: State and Non-Governmental Organization Influences on Sustainable Agricultural Practices in Senegal

Study abroad: Université Paris Ouest Nanterre La Défense (2015), City University of Hong Kong (2016)

TEACHING EXPERIENCE

University of California, Berkeley — Graduate Student Instructor

Fall 2025

- Assisted with mini lectures, assignments, and demos
- Taught 2 sections of 30 students and grading

PROFESSIONAL EXPERIENCE

Export Trading Group — Agribusiness Intern, Malawi

May 2025 – Aug. 2025

- Conducted technical due diligence and sustainability assessments on agroforestry carbon-credit projects for 2,000+ smallholder farmers, modeling carbon sequestration potentials and designing revenue-share frameworks to attract impact investors.
- Designed a Climate Desk toolkit and accompanying visuals for smallholder farmers on carbon credits, soil-health benefits, and revenue projections.

Resilient Cities Network — Program Manager, Climate Resilience & Equity, New York

Jun. 2022 – 2024

- Collaborated with city officials, community-based organizations, and stakeholders to identify and scale community-centric resilience solutions addressing climate risks and socioeconomic inequities.
- Designed and conducted household surveys and key informant interviews across 250+ households, informing tailored interventions for extreme heat and flooding in four frontline environmental justice communities.
- Conducted pre-feasibility studies and identified 10 viable climate resilience projects, leading to the selection and initiation of 5 projects with a combined budget of \$500,000, benefiting over 10,000 urban residents.
- Led the Urban Eats campaign to inspire cities to adopt circular and resilient food systems and attract funding support.
- Spearheaded the technical development and global deployment of the Resilient Infrastructure for Diversity and Equity (RIDE) Scorecard across 10 cities, with potential to impact over 2 million urban residents.

Matriark Foods — Project Consultant, New York

Oct. 2021 – Mar. 2022

- Researched and recommended vegetables and producers in line with sustainable sourcing criteria.
- Conducted upcycled foods market research and quantitative analysis to inform go-to-market strategy.
- Designed and implemented company-wide environmental, social, and governance reporting processes.

Sky High Farm — Food Access Program Consultant, New York

May 2021 – Oct. 2021

- Utilized sustainable agriculture practices to produce food for distribution to the food-insecure.
- Conducted needs assessments and collaborated with community organizations on food security initiatives.

Rethink Food — Policy Researcher, New York**Feb. 2020 – Apr. 2021**

- Co-led strategic development and execution of Rethink Food's food policy strategy, legislative agenda, and revenue goals.
- Facilitated 30+ strategic partnerships with restaurants, directing funding and resources to combat food insecurity.
- Led targeted lobbying and advocacy campaigns, liaising with elected officials and community leaders.
- Identified viable government funding opportunities and prepared grant applications and contract proposals.

Spaces — Community Manager, New York**Dec. 2018 – Jan. 2020**

- Co-managed a seven-floor co-working space with over 100 companies.
- Built an active community through client programming; partnered with intergovernmental agencies on pitch competitions and coordinated logistics across five events with 300+ attendees.

Schneider Electric — Sustainability Analyst, Budapest**Jan. 2018 – Aug. 2018**

- Oversaw sustainability reporting for 15 companies, achieving a 10% reduction in energy consumption and 15% reduction in carbon emissions.
- Managed 20+ electricity and gas utility vendors and researched climate policy and compliance strategies for clients.

Impact Hub Budapest — Community Host, Budapest, Hungary**Feb. 2017 – Jul. 2017**

- Welcomed co-working members and space guests; fostered connections between community members to support innovation.

HONORS AND AWARDS

Mentored Research Award (Full Tuition and Stipend), UC Berkeley**2026–2027****Center for African Studies Rocca Pre-dissertation Research Award, UC Berkeley****Summer 2026****Berkeley Economy and Society Initiative Award****Summer 2026****Chancellor's Fellowship (Full Tuition and Stipend), UC Berkeley****2024–2025****Central European University Research Travel Grant****2017****Central European University Master's Excellence Scholarship (Full Tuition and Stipend)****2016****Benjamin A. Gilman International Scholarship****2016****Benjamin Franklin Travel Grant****2015****Dean's List, College of Staten Island**

CONFERENCE PRESENTATIONS

Association of American Geographers Annual Meeting**2026**

"What Do You Mean You Have No Forex?": Foreign Exchange Shortages, Food Security, and Economic Development in Landlocked Malawi — Accepted and Presented

Oxford Food Symposium**2026**

"From Poverty Food to Global Superfood: Can Fonio Escape the Quinoa Trap?" — Accepted and Presented

Society for the Advancement of Socio-Economics**2026**

"Quinoa and Teff Ran so Fonio Could Walk: Beyond the Superfood Cycle and Toward a Proactive Political Economy of Fonio and Underutilized Species" — Accepted

SKILLS

Languages: English (Native), Dagbanli (Native), Twi (Proficient), Hausa (Proficient), French (Elementary)

Research Methods: Household Surveys, Focus Groups, Key Informant Interviews, Participant Observation

Technology: Microsoft Office, G Suite, ArcGIS, SPSS

Project Management: Asana, Miro, Airtable